# Wonder of the World

## By David Lindsay-Abaire

**CASS: (Pg 27)** My name's Cass. And I just left my husband. *(hum the Newlywed Game Theme Song)**

*****FLASHBACK*****

*(Cass is packing a suitcase. A door slams off stage. Cass looks up, frozen)*

**KIP: (Pg 17-22)** *(Off-stage)* Hey Sweetie! Guess who's home for lunch?! *(Cass futilely tries to hide the suitcase)* Cass? Where are ya? *(Kip enters)*

**CASS:** ince when do you come home for lunch?

**KIP:** *(notices the suitcase)* What's that? Are we going on a trip?

**CASS:** Not exactly, no. I'm leaving you.

**KIP:** You were just gonna run away without telling me?

**CASS:** I was gonna leave a note. Can you just stand in the corner until I'm done? *(goes back to packing)*

**KIP:** Is this about what I told you last night? *(no answer)* Just last week we played Yahtzee. I thought we were happy.

**CASS:** Yeah, that was a lot of fun. *(beat)* Really, this has nothing to do with you.

**KIP:** Then what happened?

**CASS:** Nothing. I just . . . I think I made a mistake. Remember that time you proposed, and I said yes?

**KIP:** That wasn't a mistake.

**CASS:** But what if it was? Look, I agreed to marry you based on what I knew to be true. Kip equals X. X will make me happy. Everything added up. Seven Years later I find out you're not X at all, you're Z. I did the math wrong. Z is no good. I would never have said yes to Z. *(beat)* This is turning into a scene.

**KIP: (Pg 23-24)** I thought this wasn't about me.

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**CASS:** I was lying when I said that. *(beat)* Why are you making me sad? I don't want to be sad. I'm a new person today. Happy! Bubbly! I'm starting a new life and brimming with expectation! There are possibilities where I'm headed!

## INTRODUCTION

*Cass and Kip . . . the perfect marriage; or so it seemed. Until Cass upset the apple cart and heads off to Niagara Falls, bucket list in hand and eager to explore (beat) by herself.*

*Wonder of the World by David Lindsay-Abaire*

**CASS:** *(back to present day)* **(Pg 27)** *(Carries her suitcase to the door of a motel, sets it down as she fumbles with the lock. She picks ups the suitcase and heads inside as she talks to the audience)* I've never been to Niagara Falls before. I almost went once. A family trip. But then Kip proposed, so I stayed behind to plan our wedding, and my parents went without me. They hit a beaver on the drive up, lost control of the car, and drove into a ditch. My mother was killed and my father's legs were crushed.

**LOIS:** *(speaks as the voice of Cass's conscience)* That man saved your life, you know. If he hadn't proposed, you would've been in that car wreck.

**CASS:** You know what? I thought the same thing for a long time, but now I think if he hadn't proposed, I would've gone with my parents, and yelled, "Dad, look out for that beaver!" And my mother would still be alive, and we would've gone on to see Niagara Falls, and maybe I would've met another man, the one I was meant to be with, instead of that two-faced deviant I married. **(Pg 28)** I had this list of all the things I wanted to do in life, but for some reason I put it away when I married Kip. P.S. BIG MISTAKE. *(pulls out a list)* Here it is. Number one is "Find your soul mate." Ignore the checkmark. That one's a do-over. Number two: Learn Swedish. Wear a large wig. *(She takes a moment to put on a large wig)* **(Pg 29)** Then we've got Have a baby. Wear overalls. Go parachuting. Become friends with a clown. Kips afraid of clowns, so . . Go on the Newlywed Game. Only Kip refused to audition. *(beat, she gets lost in a memory)* **(Pg 38)** In high school, I was a lifeguard and the only person I ever saved from drowning was Kip. That's how we met. I saved his life. I

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used to think that was fate, but now I think it was just a coincidence. A coincidence that eventually led to the death of my mother. *(embarrassed)* **(Pg 50)** I used to speak lucidly. But someone disappointed me in unspeakable ways, and now my synapses don't work all the way. *(beat)* **(Pg 81)** People used to say that Kip and I were a sweet couple. We were like yummy little bon-bons. *(heavy sigh as she decides to reveal the truth)*

**(Pg 82)** Kip has a sweater drawer. And I noticed that he was always wearing the sweaters from the front of the drawer, but never the ones from the back. So, I thought I'd rotate the sweaters. And while I was rotating. I found a box. A carved wooden box that we had bought on our honeymoon in Mexico. And it brough back all these nice memories of beaches and Mayan temples. And then I opened it. *(beat, obviously distraught)* And inside . . . were Barbie heads. **(Pg 83)** Detached. Eleven of them. And they all had crazy mangy hair. And dulled faces. And a strange disinfectant smell. And I thought, "Well, this is strange." *(beat)* Not just the Barbie heads exactly, but the fact that Kip had a secret. *(beat)* That night I held out the box and I said, What is this?" And his eyes got real big and he started sweating and then he cried. And I thought, "Well this can't be good." *(beat)* And after an hour of utter silence he proceeded to tell me that he had started collecting the heads and cleaning them and naming them, and what I found was his little collection. *(pulls out a mangy Barbie head)* **(Pg 84)** This one is Vivian! *(defiantly)* I stole one. I carry it as a reminder. Every time I miss Kip or think of going back to him, I pull out Vivian and it all comes flooding back to me. *(puts head away)* All those years, while I was folding our clothes, he was living this strange secret life, totally separate from me. What else has he not told me? He made me feel so empty. Because I had no secrets. *(spins around with arms outspread)* And that's why I came here. To fill myself up. To stuff myself with whatever I want. Gorge myself until I'm ready to burst. **(Pg 110)** Why can't people just be who you want them to be? *(A knock at the door – she peers though the peephole)* **(Pg 87)** It's Kip.

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**KIP:** **(Pg 88)** *(knocking while balancing a box on his hip)* Cass, are you in there? Please let me in.

**CASS:** **(Pg 89)** *(opens the door to confront Kip)* Kip, go home. You're gonna muck everything up.

**KIP:** After you left, I had an anxiety attack.

**CASS:** *(sarcastically)* Why, you have to empty the dishwasher yourself?

**KIP:** **(Pg 90)** Why are you being so mean? *(notices her wig)* And what is that?

**CASS:** It's a wig.

**KIP:** Why would you wear a wig? Your hair is so nice. Your hair is probably my favorite thing about you. *(a lightbulb goes off)* **(Pg 91)** This was a test, wasn't it? I was supposed to prove something back at the house; and I didn't, I just let you go. But really you wanted me to fight for you. *(Excited now, he begins to pull items from the box)* I 've brought some things. It's evidence. See? Our photo album, champagne glasses from the wedding, my swim trunks from the day we met.

**CASS:** It's just stuff, Kip.

**KIP:** I'm sorry, but you can't just wake up one day and say our marriage didn't exist. **(Pg 92)** Why are you doing this to me?! Can't you see I'm having a breakdown?!

**CASS:** I'm not your lifeguard anymore. I'm not gonna jump back in the pool just because you're splashing around.

**KIP:** I'll see a specialist. I'll get that *(beat)* ***thing*** *(beat)* taken care of.

**CASS:** **(Pg 93)** See, it's always about you, Kip. What you did. What you want. What's the matter with you?

**KIP:** **(Pg 94)** *(Collapses, sobbing)* I'm sorry! Okay?! What else do I need to do? Just tell me and I'll do it. I know I was dishonest. I know you're disappointed but give me another chance.

**CASS:** **(Pg 96)** Excuse me! *(whips out the doll head and shakes it at him)* Excuuuuuuuse me!

**KIP:** I was wondering where Vivian went. I wanted to dispose of her. As I did the other.

**CASS:** Go home, Kip. You're wasting your time here.

**KIP:** **(Pg 111)** I called a marriage counselor on our behalf. **(Pg 112)** Glen says this therapist is a miracle worker.

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**CASS:** Well, that's swell, but I'm not a blind deaf mute.

**KIP:** Just give it a chance. She said she'd get here ASAP.

**CASS:** Get here? This is my room! You can't just invite people over! *(beat)* **(Pg 115)** If we sit down with the counselor and talk, are you gonna stop acting like a crazy person.

**KIP:** Yes. Of course. If she counsels us to the best of her ability, and you still feel . . .

**CASS:** Contempt and loathing.

**KIP:** Okay. If you still feel those things, then I'll go home.

**JANIE:** **(Pg 121)** *(enters, dressed as a clown, big shoes; the works)* Hello! *(honks horn)*

**KIP:** *(terrified, screams)* She's a clown! *(Cass laughs)*

**JANIE:** *(very professional in manner, no funny voice or anything silly)* Only part-time. *(gesturing to her costume)* for the kids at the hospital.

**KIP:** **(Pg 122)** *(composing himself)* I'm the one who hired you. Don't you wanna change?

**JANIE:** Nah, I'm good. The fact that you have the money, and you're the husband, means *nothing* to me. Now sit down and we can get started. *(Shaking hands with Cass)* My name is Janie McShane.

**CASS:** You know what's great, Janie? I was kind of dreading you, but now that you're here, it feels totally right. I have this whole conundrum about fate, and one of the things on my list is become friends with a clown . . . and here you are!

**JANIE:** Okay. I'm guessing you're a little unbalanced. Am I right.

**CASS:** Is that what Kip told you?

**JANIE:** You see these things on the side of my head? They're called ears. And they pick up crackpot real clear. Now have a seat next to that gnome you call hubby. *(Cass and Kip set and Janine gets to work)* **(Pg 126)** What do you want from your husband right now?

**CASS:** I want him to . . . disappear.

**JANIE:** Good. Good. Next? *(She turs to Kip)*

**KIP:** *(clears his throat, stand up to present as if at an AA meeting)* My name is Kip, and my wife left me because I am a deviant. And I want things to be the way they used to be.

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**JANIE:** Well, that's impossible, you moron. No wonder your wife left you. **(Pg 129)** It's too early to determine who does and doesn't belong together. First, I have to find out how well you know each other. And in order to do that we need to play the Newlywed Game. *(honks her hand horn)*

**CASS:** *(giddy)* Oh, I love that game! *(hum the Newlywed Game Theme Song)**

**KIP:** **(Pg 130)** That's it! The whole thing is off! I don't like games! And I don't like clowns! This is everything I don't like!

**CASS:** And everything I do like, Kip. I'm sorry she's not what you had in mind, but sometimes that's what happens in life. If you want to call it off, then we're done. It's up to you.

**KIP:** *(defeated pause)* Okay. Let's play.

**JANIE:** Now I'm gonna pass out some questions and I want you to write down the answers on these cards. No peeking. *(passes out cue cards, markers and questions)* **(Pg 131)** Each question is worth twenty points. Question Number 1: What is your husband's pet name for you? Cass?

**CASS:** Well, there are a few, but mostly he calls me lifesaver.

**KIP:** *(flips his card and pumps his fist in the air)* Yes! Lifesaver it is! *(Cass smiles)*

**JANIE:** **(Pg 133)** Cass, Kip's first words to you?

**CASS:** I believe he said . . . "Help, help. I can't swim. Holy crap, I'm drowning."

**KIP:** *(flips card and grins, bell rings) (to Cass)* And you said we were strangers.

**JANIE:** **(Pg 134-135)** Now it's the husband's turn. Okay one question left, and it's a bonus question worth 35 points. Kip, If you had to describe your wife as a fairytale character, which one would it be? **(Pg 136)** You need to get this right, or you go home empty-handed.

**KIP:** I understand. Well . . . *(to Cass)* Remember in high school you had that long hair? Rapunzel! My answer is Rapunzel.

**JANIE:** **(Pg 137)** Flip the card please.

**CASS:** *(sadly)* Rapunzel is locked away in a tower, cut off from the rest of the world. *(She flips the card) (Buzzer sounds)*

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**KIP:** Wait! Do over! She didn't understand the question! She said Jack! *(to Cass)* Jack and the Beanstalk Jack? **(Pg 138)** That's not even a girl. How was I supposed to guess that? How is Jack better than Rapunzel?

**CASS:** Jack steals eggs and kills giants and chops things down! Jack does things. Jack lives life! Rapunzel sits around combing her hair all day.

**KIP:** She gets out of the tower eventually. The prince frees her or something.

**CASS:** *(beat)* But you're not the prince, Kip. You're not the prince in this story!

**KIP:** **(Pg 139)** This is just a game!

**CASS:** It's not just a game. Things have meaning, Kip. Or at least they should. My life should have meaning. And I don't think it does when I'm with you. You could've said anything. You could've said something wonderful and changes my mind. God, I would have loved that. But you said Rapunzel. After everything, you still don't – I mean look at me! Do I look like a Rapunzel. [I'm Jack] Jack does things. Jack lives life! *(whips out her list again)* **(Pg 29)** Eat venison . . . *(shakes her head)* Visit a prison *(shakes her head)* Go parachuting! YES! *(she honks Janie's horn and exits with a flourish)*

## SOURCE INFORMATION

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## AWARD HISTORY

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****Newlywed Game Theme Song can be found here***
***https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=UvulxN8hY6o***

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